

Playing in the “Third Place”: How Games and Play Are Transforming Public Libraries

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Abstract

Games and play are a growing presence in public libraries, part of a suite of new spaces and services that respond to digitization and new urban policy imperatives. Drawing on observation of library spaces and interviews with library staff in Australia, Finland, and Singapore ($n = 27$), we examine the myriad ways games and play are transforming the library: from its architectural design and furnishings to its daily rhythms, atmosphere, and acoustics. Games and play, we argue, are more than adjuncts to traditional library services. Often spilling out of designated zones and beyond the library’s walls, they mirror the wider integration of libraries into urban policy agendas and the city’s economic and cultural life. This trend underscores the growing tensions libraries face in balancing their conscription into instrumental objectives with their traditional role as “third places” bounded by the utilitarian demands of work and home.

Keywords

creative cities, cultural policy, games, play, public libraries, smart cities, third place

Introduction

A library is a public place and users must show due consideration and respect for others. Parents are responsible for educating and reminding their children that the library is not a playground, and children should not run and shout on the premises [. . .] Let us critically view the actual situation, before libraries turn into substitute nurseries, kindergartens or playgrounds, losing their original role as places for learning.

—excerpt from a letter to *The Straits Times* (Lau Pet Keong, 2020)

The growing visibility of play in public libraries has been well recognized, both within the discipline of library and information studies and by library users themselves. Numerous books over the last decade have promoted the usefulness of games to childhood education, community building, or attracting new users to the library. Others provide practical advice to librarians on how to make gaming programs successful (Gallaway, 2009; A. Harris & Rice, 2008; Kirsch, 2014;

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Mayer & Harris, 2009; Neiburger, 2007; Nichols, 2010). These discussions extend into library science journals (see, e.g., Adams, 2009; Brown & Kasper, 2013; Cilauro, 2015; Inklebarger, 2018; Thomas & Clyde, 2013; Woodson et al., 2011) as well as library networks and conferences (see, e.g., ALA GameRT, n.d.). “Play” in this research features in the form of “artifacts” for loan and for preservation: videogame disks, board games, and toys; some libraries even lend sporting equipment. “Play” also features as “gaming”: programmed activity involving physical or computer games within the library, held as part of a regular program or one-off event. Collectively, this literature attests to the burgeoning enthusiasm for making the contemporary library a space of play (Burek Pierce, 2016), and showcases the range of strategies libraries are employing to make these programs attractive to the public.

However, as practitioner-focused literature, usually documenting single case studies, this research reveals little about the role of play in the library’s wider transformation; nor does it connect the “playful library” to a broader transition toward digital urbanism, the creative city, and post-industrial development. The expansion of games and play in public libraries runs parallel to the growing status of play in the cultural and economic life of cities (Stevens, 2017). Apprehending this bigger picture means engaging with “play” at a more fundamental level: not only as an artifact and activity but as a philosophical concept deeply intertwined with Western conceptions of work, private leisure, and the modern city. As public libraries become increasingly “playful” in their design, services, and orientation to the public, they also elevate the role of play within 21st-century urbanism and the transition to digital capitalism. This is because the trust they have enjoyed as long-standing institutions of universal access, learning, and public leisure (Audunson, 2005; Billington, 1998) gives them a certain authority in mediating structural transitions. As Sara Ahmed (2012) argues, institutions not only stabilize relations and processes, they also manage change.

This article argues that play is a significant feature of the library’s spatial and functional transformation. More than simply relating to the acquisition of new objects and facilities to extend library collections, play has become integral to transforming what the library is as a cultural institution and public space. This playful transformation is connected to deeper disruptions to patterns of work, education, and leisure that characterize urban life in the digital economy. While nominally considered in opposition to the instrumental functions of modern urban life, theorists have long identified the potential for play to be conscripted into discourses and agendas that serve visions of post-industrial urban development, knowledge capital, and the entrepreneurial citizen (Dyer-Witheford & de Peuter, 2009; Huizinga, 1944/1949; Kücklich, 2005). As Graeme Kirkpatrick (2013) argues, digital games have served as instrumental technologies of adaptation to the logics of digital capitalism. Meanwhile, the long-standing association between play and self-directed learning makes games and playfulness an appealing heuristic for introducing young subjects to the demands of flexible, post-Fordist citizenship (Fraser, 2003). Examining how play features in public libraries reveals something of the way they are contributing to an emergent civic culture in which conditions of labor, production, leisure, and sociality are in flux.

This article draws from observations and interviews with 27 library staff and managers conducted between 2015 and 2020, primarily in Finland and Australia, as well as examples from Singapore and the United States. We illustrate how libraries, from flagship developments to modest suburban branches, are being reconfigured spatially, temporally, and functionally through games and play. The similarities in the uptake of games and play across diverse library settings suggest a broad shift in how they imagine their services and relationship to the city, one that exceeds the policy settings of individual cities or the innovations of a single institution. Even so, our fieldwork and other literature also reveal how legitimizing play in libraries sits uneasily with prevailing views of the institution as a cathedral of knowledge and learning. As our opening epigraph suggests, expanded opportunities for play in libraries, and the increasing playfulness of their spaces, is a source of public tension as well as internal institutional debate.

Play itself has long been the subject of contentious scholarly debate (see Henricks, 2006; Huizinga, 1944/1949; Lütticken, 2010; Nagel, 2002). As Quentin Stevens (2017, p. 177) observes, while often understood in opposition to work, play “also resists the dualism of Western thinking” and eludes easy definition. A full exposition of the philosophical thought around play is beyond the scope of this article. However, one of the most salient ways play relates to libraries is in its theorization as a non-essential activity associated with leisure and sociality, and in opposition to the instrumental functions of modern urban life (Caillois, 2001; Huizinga, 1944/1949; Stevens, 2017). For library and information studies, this understanding is invoked through the common characterizing of the library as a “third place”: that place between home and work which offers respite from the conventions, roles, and rules governing life in the modern industrial city. From this conceptual basis, public libraries might be considered as always having been play spaces because participation is voluntary and also because they provide environments and resources for enrichment beyond the demands of productive labor. In this sense, the presence of games in libraries—whether in the form of collections of physical board games, the provision of sporting equipment, or digital gaming programs like *Minecraft* clubs or robotics workshops—is only part of the reason we claim them as “playgrounds.” While many of our case studies exemplify the new ways games are being mobilized in contemporary libraries, grasping the complex, even contradictory significance of this phenomenon requires apprehending play in a broader sense.

Promotion of the library as a third place has become almost axiomatic in library and information science. However, the term obscures the contemporary “playful” library’s increasing erosion of these very distinctions: both in the way play serves instrumental agendas around urban redevelopment and digital capitalism, and how play is reformatting library spaces in ways that intentionally blur the boundaries separating it from the city beyond its walls. We begin this article by accounting for some of the limitations in framing the library as a “third place.” We then illustrate the diverse ways play is manifesting in and transforming public libraries—from dramatic new architectural developments to subtle and incremental changes in their ambiance and acoustics. We aim to illustrate how play, in its various manifestations, is not simply an adjunct to the library’s established institutional function, but rather, is linked to many of the imperatives that drive contemporary urban development policies, ideals of citizenship, and visions of urban life.

The Library as “Third Place”

Libraries have become associated with play through an extensive body of literature claiming them as “third places”: a place between home and work. The term “third place” is drawn from sociologist, Ray Oldenburg’s 1989/1997 book, *The Great Good Place*, a nostalgic critique of the loss of community in the expanding middle-class suburbias of post-war North America. In a much-cited phrase, Oldenburg defined third places as “public places that host the regular, voluntary, informal and happily anticipated gathering of individuals” (Oldenburg in Pomerantz & Marchionini, 2007, p. 517). These places are important, he argues, because they invite a sense of play and playfulness that is largely absent from the increasingly privatized, regulated, and predictable nature of industrialized North American modernity. In an article preceding the publication of *The Great Good Place*, Oldenburg and Brissett (1982) argue that the suspension of home and work is crucial for the dynamics of play to emerge:

The basis of the “play” or the delight in association is not found in what sociologists call the “role requirements” inherent in the job to be done, but in the sense of individuality which emerges from these roles and the interplay between them. (pp. 270–271).

Far from exemplifying a third place, libraries are excluded from Oldenburg’s list because he considers them too large, formal, and bureaucratic to offer this spontaneous “sense of individuality”

and sociality to emerge. Rather, it is cafés, coffee houses, burger joints, diners, and the neighborhood post office, which feature as representative examples: spaces which are “typically modest, inexpensive, and small by comparison” (Oldenburg, 1989/1997, p. 198). What these spaces offer, he argues, is a “kind of belonging” related neither to “personal advantage nor civic duty. The basic motivation, that which draws people back time and again is *fun*” (Oldenburg, 1989/1997, p. 20).

Oldenburg’s exclusion of libraries from his suite of third places has not deterred library and information studies from appropriating the term to advocate for the library’s public value. In this literature, third place is a particularly attractive concept to reinforce the continuing relevance of the library as a physical space, even as digital archives make its collections widely available online (Aabø et al., 2010; Bilandzic & Foth, 2013; C. Harris, 2007; Houghton et al., 2013; Pomerantz & Marchionini, 2007; Varaprasad et al., 2005). U.S. librarian Peter Bromberg’s (2006) blog post, “Library as Place,” is typical of these kinds of arguments:

“Libraries are transformative places. By our very nature we offer people a ‘third place’ (not home, not work) where they can come to explore, imagine, think, learn, play, and reflect. Our function as a ‘third place’ has never been more important to our continued health and relevance” (n.p.).

Another body of literature employs the third place concept to present sociological accounts of the library’s contribution to building social capital and forms of cross-cultural belonging (Aabø & Audunson, 2012; Aabø et al., 2010; Audunson, 2005; Cilauro, 2015). This work makes loftier claims for the importance of libraries as “low-intensive meeting places” for building community as a foundation for “democracy in a multicultural context” (Audunson, 2005, p. 430).

Oldenburg’s concept of third place aims to recapture the small-town rituals and forms of community that characterized pre-World War II small-town American life. In adopting the term, libraries have adapted this nostalgia for their own purposes. But while useful and attractive for advocating for the social importance of investing in libraries as *physical places*, “third place” arguments homogenize vastly different urban settings and obscure the profound changes in patterns of work and leisure that have transformed cities in the 21st century. If the third place is defined by its clear distinction between home and work, how does it apply to the fragmentation and redistribution of work precipitated by the networked technologies of the digital economy? As Melissa Gregg (2011) has argued, expectations of ubiquitous connectivity have created conditions for work to expand well beyond the workplace, permeating the home and social life in increasingly insidious ways. Equally, it might be argued that these same technologies redistribute access to leisure, creating momentary opportunities for play and social connection *within* the confines of routinized labour and domestic reproduction. Uncritical acceptance of the library as a third place also suppresses deeper questions around the library’s social function at a time when, far from being imprisoned in stable occupations in predictable suburban lives, people are expected to be ever more mobile and flexible to the demands of capital (Sennett, 1998), to be entrepreneurs of the self in exchange for greater precarity (McRobbie, 2018).

Libraries have been highly adaptive to the new demands of their public in a digital culture. One of the significant features of the library’s relatively recent transformation is the erosion of this separation and sense of suspension from economic labor that has historically marked it as a distinctive civic institution. In their architectural design and orientation, libraries are increasingly seeking physical spatial connection to the public spaces, parks, plazas, and shopping malls of the city. Branding themselves as entrepreneurial hubs, hosting co-working spaces and facilities for start-ups, and co-locating with training centers and social service providers, they are also inviting the activities of urban economic life into their spaces. In these new institutional configurations, libraries signpost their credentials as more than places for intellectual enrichment; they position themselves as active contributors to the knowledge economy.

Global trends in library design and programming reflect the changing conditions of work and leisure precipitated by the rapid expansion of networked digital technologies into all aspects of

social and economic life. As libraries respond to these conditions and promote themselves as central to the city's digital transformation, they continue to be spaces of play, but in a sense very different to the bounded sanctuary, separate from home and work, upon which claims for the library as a "third place" rest. In what follows, we examine this expansion of play in public libraries, illustrating the multitude of ways they are aligned with an emerging post-industrial civic culture and digital citizen.

Play in the Past: A Brief History of Games in Public Libraries

Historical studies of public libraries document their adoption of games and play since their origins in the mid-19th century. While a full account of this history is beyond the scope of this article, this literature draws our attention to three relevant points. First, the increasing playfulness of contemporary libraries is not a new innovation, but rather, a return to the more versatile, multi-sensory, and experimental institutions they were aspiring to be in the early decades of their history (Burek Pierce, 2016; Cottrell, 2013; Nicholson, 2013). Second, "play" appeared in a variety of forms and served multiple functions: attracting new users, educating the young, and providing moral guidance. British libraries, for example, introduced "[g]ame rooms and billiard parlours" for working-class men in cities, to "lure" them out of public houses "into a more 'appropriate' location for these games" (Nicholson, 2013, p. 343). Third, the inclusion of games and play in libraries was not uncontested. As Scott Nicholson observes, for as long as libraries have integrated games into their collections and programming, they have been met with resistance from some library patrons and librarians themselves. Critics question the inclusion of games when funding is limited. They express fears that games and other leisure activities will "replace" books and erode the library's role as a place of serious learning and exponent of informed, moral citizenship (Shera, 1949, p. 239).

These concerns persist for contemporary libraries. Along with the practical challenges of managing game collections and acquiring the necessary skillsets to include digital games within library programs, librarians must manage the noise and disruption to other patrons that games bring into library spaces; and defend themselves against accusations that games are frivolous, along with public concerns around their violent or sexual content (see Nicholson, 2013, p. 344). In response, libraries have justified the integration of games into their collections and programming by promoting their potential benefits and highlighting their growing social relevance. These justifications recurred in our interviews with librarians and library managers (See Online Appendix for a full list of interviews). They told us that their gaming programs were successful in attracting "people who wouldn't ordinarily come to the library" (Clayton transcript, 2015); and were "a way for us to try and break down the stereotypes of what libraries are [and] appeal to a broader spectrum of the community" (Wilmott transcript, 2015). Several of our interviewees deflected potential criticisms of games as "frivolous" entertainment by emphasizing their educational and developmental potential:

You might not approve of the concept of playing a game. It's a controlled time. They get half an hour each so it's not like they're on it, you know, till their eyes go square. But it's still building those social skills. I'd much rather they were coming into an environment where they're working together, talking, interacting, than maybe at home in their bedrooms playing it without any engagement. So I see it no different to any of those clubs that we would have run quite acceptably 20 years ago (Clayton transcript, 2015).

Both of these justifications—games as an educational tool, or for attracting new patrons—echo previous debates (Nicholson, 2013, p. 344). The 19th-century game rooms and billiard parlor for the working class "combine[d] recreation with education in a controlled setting." Many of the board games libraries offered had explicit moral overtones: players progressed by making good moral choices and were set back for landing on spaces that represented "vices" (Nicholson, 2013,

p. 343). Children's rooms, like playgrounds—which emerged around the same time—were similarly identified by reformists as demarcated spaces for proscribed and sanctioned leisure and play activities, countering what Jane Addams (1909, p. 14) describes as the “temptations” of the streets and other public spaces (see Burek Pierce, 2016, pp. 376–378; Lauwaert, 2009, pp. 37–38). While these attitudes seem dated today, they resonate with the sentiments of our interviewees who emphasized the “controlled time” and “educational” value of play in libraries.

The People's Playground

Finland's public libraries offer a portrait of what libraries might be like if they embrace all aspects of play, games, and gaming culture. Finland has a strong tradition of public investment in libraries and boasts among the highest visitation rates and loans per capita in the world (Ministry of Education, 2016; Reith-Banks, 2018). Their progressive approach is reflected in the work of Heikki Marjomaa, employed by the City of Helsinki to consult with its 37 public libraries about integrating games into their service.

Libraries are a very unique place for games, because we view games as just an extension of other cultural media. So it's always about stories, it's always about culture, it's always about art. So that's what I try to get people to understand, that games have a very solid place in the library (Marjomaa transcript, 2019).

Marjomaa identifies four overarching ways that games figure in Finnish public libraries. They are part of their collections; represent “important cultural content” for preservation, particularly as games and gaming platforms disappear (see Newman, 2012); extend library services through gaming clubs and events; and offer the opportunity for exposure to “fairly new media” that public can access through game education and literacy programs (Marjomaa interview transcript, 2019).

All of these rationales for the inclusion of games are reflected in Oodi Central Library in Helsinki. Opened in 2018, Oodi is a €98m (approx. US\$110m) high-tech library development which attracted global attention for its innovative design (*Yle Uutiset*, 2019). It includes a large digital and analog gaming collection (see Figure 1) and several dedicated gaming spaces: a 14 PC Gaming Room for online multiplayer games, esports, and other “hardcore” gaming (see Figure 2); three bookable Console Rooms with the latest game consoles and virtual reality (VR) games for casual play; an Arcade Space showcasing accessible and retro games; as well as multiple rooms specifically for playing tabletop games. The library also hosts a regular role-playing game club where Marjomaa has hosted “Grasp the Games” sessions to familiarize the public with popular games. Oodi demonstrates how games have become more than a mere extension of the library's services and collections. They are dramatically reshaping the space and temporality of the library itself, not only through dedicated spaces and programs but also through embedding play into the social and material fabric of the library. This spatial and temporal reconfiguration is a visible manifestation of the way play in libraries connects with broader urban development agendas. Makerspaces, co-working spaces, robotics workshops, and digital inclusion programs are the most visible demonstrations of libraries aligning themselves with broader policy frameworks around the creative city, smart city, and digital economy. In embracing and supporting these frameworks, libraries relate to the city in new ways. In what follows, we consider the library's spatial and temporal inter-weaving of games and play as part of a more fundamental evolution of the presence of play in urban public space.

Gaming Zones

Game collections and gaming spaces are the most visible manifestation of games and play in libraries. At Iso Omena Library in Helsinki, the gaming zone is situated somewhat haphazardly



Figure 1. The Gaming Zone in Iso Omena Library in Espoo, Helsinki.

Note. A cabinet with televisions and game consoles on either side is situated in the middle of the library. A simple chess table is nearby. Photograph by author.

amid shelving, rows of seating, and its nearby makerspace (see Figure 1). In the Metso in Tampere, the gaming zone is located in a dedicated room strewn with beanbags and is usually occupied by children playing *Minecraft* (Parviainen transcript, 2019; see Figure 2).

Metso Library has similarly demarcated game-playing activity from the rest of the library with a distinct entrance and soundproofing. At Iso Omena by contrast, gaming zones are interspersed between shelving and reading areas. Play spills out into these areas sonically through their audio and the social sounds of gaming. Spatially, gaming alters the flow of people through the library, creating new gathering patterns and clusters of spectators. In some cases, players are conscious of this porosity, they keep the audio low (if they can control it) and talk quietly among themselves. On a much smaller scale, at the Kathleen Syme Library and Community Center in Melbourne, a television and game console sits in a recreational space that includes tables for casual conversation or reading, shelves of travel books, and a kitchen. This casual, social atmosphere masks the sounds of gameplay. When we visit, two boys play *Minecraft*, the older one excitedly instructing the younger, albeit at a low volume so as not to rise above the ambient noise. Justine Hanna, formerly a team leader at Kathleen Syme explains how the public are increasingly becoming accustomed to this new atmosphere in which leisure, work, and study comeingle:

there are still the people that don't like anybody to make any noise whatsoever in a library. But then the majority, I think, are really understanding that a lot of different things are happening in libraries now and they appreciate the spaces. They appreciate the activities. Even at City Library [in Melbourne's city centre], there's a piano. A lot of people really love the fact that [. . .] they are able to play a piano, and a lot of people come up and say, "Is that a recording or is it real?" (interview transcript, 2016).



Figure 2. The Gaming Room at Metso Main Library, Tampere.
Photograph by author.

New library developments are enabling some libraries to construct purpose-built facilities for games in their spaces. Of Oodi Central Library's three floors, two have no shelving or physical collections. The second floor hosts a makerspace, meeting rooms, a recording studio, a quiet study area, sewing machines, a large open-tiered seating area, and a PC gaming room. Three console rooms are situated behind an information desk along the main thoroughfare. All three have transparent glass walls allowing passers-by on either side to observe people playing console and VR games. A seating area directly facing the console rooms turns peoples' gameplay into a spectacle for visitors to watch as they relax on low, lounge-like couches (Figure 3). VR gameplay is particularly performative; immersed in the game through headsets, players twist their bodies and wave their arms. Marjomaa intimated possible discomfort with this hyper-visibility. He suggested that the library might shield the screens from non-playing viewers to protect players' privacy and prevent potentially violent game content from being visible to children.

Gaming zones affect the temporal rhythms of libraries as well as their spatiality. Marjomaa notes that during school weeks, the PC gaming room at Oodi only opens after 2 p.m. so as not to be a temptation to workers and children who should "stay in schools and stay in work" during hours meant for productivity. Gaming has increased the library's busy periods and also influenced the duration of dwell times. Rowena Wilmott, Library Technical Services Officer at Logan Central Library in Brisbane's outer suburbs, notes that although the library only tracks visitation through pedestrian counters, "we know anecdotally that people are staying for a lot longer." She

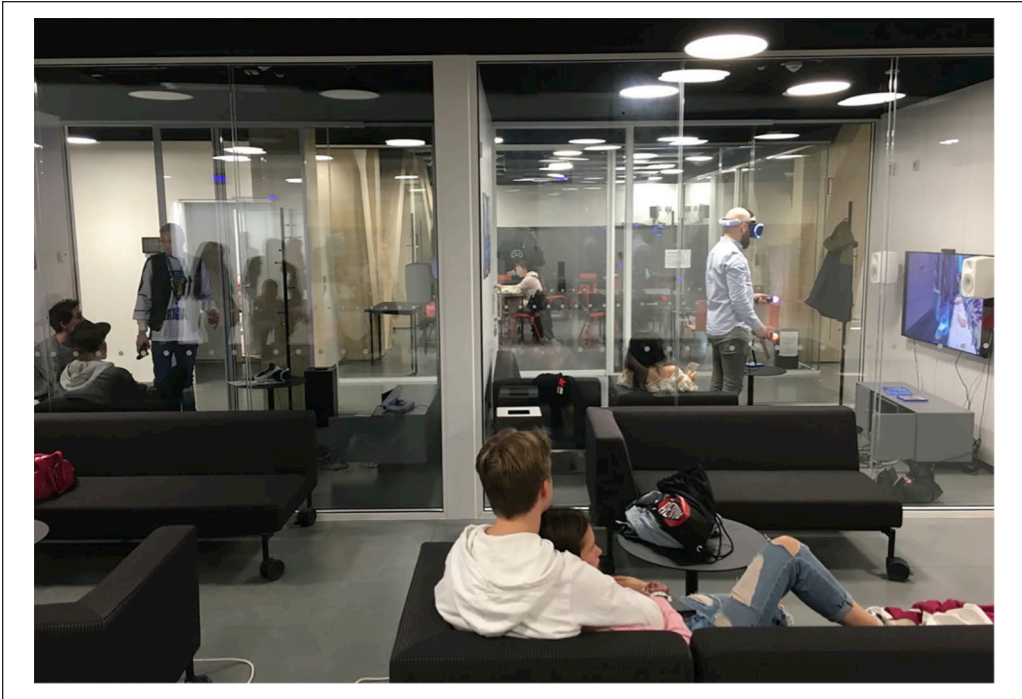


Figure 3. A Seated Couple Observe Someone Playing a PlayStation 4 Virtual Reality Game Inside One of the Bookable Console Rooms at Oodi Central Library.

Photograph by author.

says, “Things like the games, after school time, we find that there are a lot of kids who will come and use the spaces” (interview transcript, 2015). This influence extends to public libraries’ programming, with gaming days, after-school and evening games-related programs for teens and seniors, Scratch classes, and LEGO robotics workshops attracting more participants than reading clubs or public talks. Games have led to extensions in library opening hours. The Broadmeadows Library in Melbourne, for instance, provides weekly “Board Games after Dark” sessions as part of the City of Hume’s “Libraries After Dark” initiative (Hume Libraries, 2020).

Children and Teen Zones

Children’s rooms and children’s libraries emerged from the child study movement, “which intended to better young people by understanding their needs” (Burek Pierce, 2016, p. 374). Libraries recognized the need for vibrant, colorful, multimedia-rich environments that were able to compete with commercial entertainment and attract children of diverse interests and age ranges (Burek Pierce, 2016, pp. 376–379). Today, many libraries’ children’s spaces have expanded far beyond a discrete corner or separate room. Alongside teen zones and youth-dedicated spaces, children’s zones are increasingly elaborate and expansive, occupying entire sections or floors of large-scale library developments.

Singapore has invested heavily in public libraries as part of its national strategy to improve early childhood literacy and support families in residential areas with surging growth. In both library@harbourfront (opened 2019) and Bukit Panjang Public Library (renovated 2017) approximately half of each library is dedicated to children and the other for teens and adults. Both these libraries include an experimental new area called the Stories Come Alive Room. This immersive



Figure 4. The Stories Come Alive Room at library@harbourfront.
Photograph by author.

play space features interactive screens on all four walls as well as music, toys, books, and costumes to create both curated and unstructured forms of play (Figure 4). Library@harbourfront features “the first children’s makerspace in a library” (National Library Board, 2019). Announced by a large Tinker Truck at its entrance, the space aims to attract children ages 3 to 9, combining play with do-it-yourself learning programs, such as word puzzles, scheduled maker programs, and interactive augmented reality books (Figure 5).

In these children-focused library spaces, games and play form part of a strategy to encourage child literacy and education and facilitate interaction between parents and children. Equally, in an echo of the moralizing role played by 19th-century libraries, contemporary libraries are incorporating playful architecture and playground-like furniture to attract children and compete with other cultural or commercial ‘offerings’ in the city, like shopping centers, game parlors, and amusement parks. The State Library of Victoria’s Children’s Quarter—developed as part of a major redevelopment—incorporates a two-story explorable children’s castle, storytelling area, reading nooks, animal-themed seating, and a “wet-area makerspace for creative play” (State Library Victoria, n.d.; Figure 6). The Central Public Library in Singapore’s downtown core has an enchanted forest-themed children’s space called My Tree House. It features eco-friendly spaces for play and learning, including a treehouse canopy made from recycled materials, refurbished bookshelves holding green-themed books, and an interactive weather station (Figure 7).



Figure 5. The Tinker Truck at library@harbourfront.
Photograph by author.



Figure 6. The Pauline Gandel Children's Quarter at State Library Victoria, Melbourne.
Photograph by author.



Figure 7. My Tree House Children's Library at the Central Public Library, Singapore.
Photograph by author.

These kinds of investments seem to respond to a complex mix of rationalities. Ozanne and Ozanne (2011, p. 264) begin their article on toy libraries by stating that “children’s right to play” as a “fundamental right of citizenship” has been enshrined in the United Nation’s Declaration of the Rights of the Child since 1959 and by 2008, affirmed by 192 countries. Such declarations recognize play as a fundamental component of children’s development, and as such, central to the strength of democracy. The expanded forms of children’s play spaces and programs that we have surveyed across our case studies might be interpreted as institutional recognition of this deep social belief. Yet they also reflect the increasing encroachment of forms of commodification and digital capitalism into the protected zone of childhood. The library’s elaborate, sensorially enriched play spaces and programs for children not only compete with the attractions of commercial forms of play like theme parks and private playgrounds (Ozanne and Ozanne, 2011, p. 264), they also inscribe skillsets and attitudes highly valued by an economy of flexibilized, entrepreneurialized labor. Commenting on the institutional uptake of *Minecraft* programs by cultural institutions, including public libraries, Hjorth et al (2020, p. 44) identify how outside the home, *Minecraft* has become a “flexible tool for learning, literacy and sociality across diverse groups.” There are social democratic benefits to these interactions. Equally however, Hjorth et al. observe how the instrumentalizing of play “makes boundaries between notions of work and play more difficult for parents and children to distinguish” (147). Just as library makerspaces and co-working spaces service an economy for an adult workforce based upon a blurring of labor and leisure, their expanded investment in children’s play contributes to blurring the boundaries that have been essential to maintaining play’s distinct cultural significance (Huizinga, 1944/1949).

Playful Architecture and Design

New library developments increasingly embrace experimental and playfully self-referential design. The Geelong Library & Heritage Center (opened 2015) in Australia features a geodesic domed façade that simultaneously recalls “the domed reading rooms of distinguished traditional libraries” while also variously being described as resembling an igloo, a golf ball, and a giant brain. These various metaphors reflect an ambivalence around the library that vacillates between the playful and the instrumental. Besides the playfulness of many children’s spaces—animal-shaped seating and children’s castles—library interiors are similarly adopting playful designs. Vibrant colors, creatively designed stairways, shelves, and reading nooks instill a playful atmosphere while ambiguous, non-proscriptive design encourages exploration (see Ävontuura, 2019; Bibliotheca, n.d.; Indesignlive, 2019; Kvadrat Interwoven, n.d.; Rosan Bosch, n.d.a, n.d.b; See, 2015). For example, Hjørring Bibliotek in Denmark (opened 2008) features a red ribbon running throughout the library that merges with its shelving, tables, and counters, as well as interactive spaces that aim to “create *serendipity* [. . .] to activate the library as an arena for the city’s youth” (Rosan Bosch, n.d.b: n.p.).

Echoing the “Playable Cities” movement (see Nijholt, 2017, 2019; Playable City, n.d.), libraries are also incorporating interactive and responsive technologies into their spaces to make them more playful and engaging for citizens. Like the artistic interventions of “playable cities,” these projects are often experimental prototypes that have yet to be implemented on a permanent, expansive scale. Public libraries in Massachusetts, for example, have trialed Alterspace, designed by researchers at Harvard’s Library Innovation Lab. Alterspace consists of a lamp controlled via an app that changes the ambiance of the room through lighting and sound (Young, 2019; Figure 8). In 2018, Stadtteilbibliothek Köln-Kalk in Germany commissioned the interactive installation *Canvass* by design studio URBANSCREEN (2018), which projects motifs designed by visitors onto a semi-translucent screen. Oodi Library took advantage of its closure during the COVID-19 pandemic to trial Veera, a “social orientated robot” initially designed at a workshop in its makerspace, which will eventually interact with visitors (Annala, 2020). These projects all demonstrate a growing willingness by libraries to experiment with playful spaces and installations normally found in galleries or cultural precincts, and invite spontaneity, unanticipated use, and a sense of fun.

Engagement With the City’s Public Spaces

Paulina Mickiewicz (2016) describes a growing trend for contemporary libraries to be in dialogue with their external environments and “let the outside in.” Through “vast, fluid spaces with high ceilings and large windows that take in the surrounding environment, and allow for natural light to filter into what was once a muted interior [. . .] the library has been transformed into a space wherein the outside, the presence of the street, has become central to its contemporary needs” (Mickiewicz, 2016, p. 244). Examples such as the coliseum-esque façade of Vancouver Public Library Central Branch (opened 1995), the Seattle Central Library (opened 2004), and Mickiewicz’s case study of Montreal’s Grande Bibliothèque (opened 2005) vividly illustrate this trend. Two recent public libraries have explicitly integrated outdoor spaces for play into their design, bridging their interior zones for gaming and playful activities with their surroundings.

Dokk1 in Aarhus recognizes play as one of its core design principles. Opened in 2015 as part of a major redevelopment of the city’s waterfront, its entire ground floor is encircled by a play area called Kloden (“The Globe”). Resembling a compass, the area is designed to encourage play and physical activity through climbable sculptures of animals from each continent. It offers a panoramic view of the city’s harbor front, now redesigned as a cultural precinct and meeting place for the city’s inhabitants, while also symbolically invoking the library’s broader connection

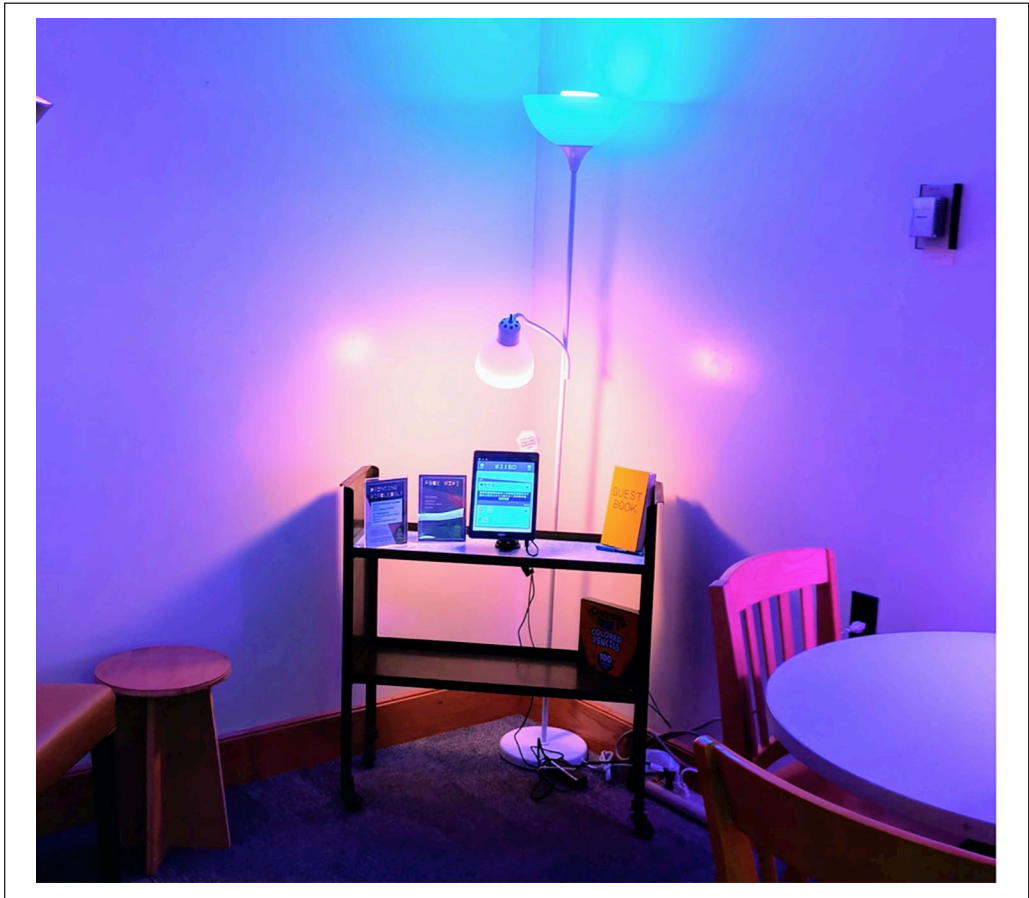


Figure 8. Alterspace in Situ at an Unknown Library.
Photograph provided by Alterspace designers, used with permission.

to the world as a repository of knowledge. As the official book about the library's development explains, "The Globe as a whole reaches out towards the boundaries of the city, linking Aarhus with the rest of the world" (Hapel et al., 2015, p. 108). This architectural playfulness extends inside Dokk1's spaces, which includes "a number of permanent and multi-purpose play areas" (Stine Liv Johansen, quoted in Hapel et al., 2015, p. 72) which have been the setting for the CounterPlay festival multiple times (Poulson, 2015).

The Library and the City: Rethinking the Third Place Through Play

More comprehensively than any of our other examples, Oodi Helsinki Central Library exemplifies a new design ethos that reframes the library as an urban playground. A three-story structure of glass, steel, and wood, the library is deliberately sited on prime development land, adjacent to the train station, overlooking a public plaza and facing Helsinki's national parliament building to underscore its importance to Finnish society. Another face of the building integrates the library with spaces of civic leisure; the ground floor opens out onto a large park including a playground, outdoor gym, basketball court, and other recreational facilities. The development attracts

metaphors of mobility and connectivity: it has been described as a “ship topped with a layer of ice” (Rogers, 2018). Finnish firm, ALA Architects who won the commission for the brief, designed the building on the principle of “an inhabited bridge, with two massive steel arches that span over 100 meters to create a fully enclosed, column-free public entrance space” (ArchDaily, 2018, n.p.). Promotional images accentuate the lack of obstruction in many of its central spaces. In its cavernous, high ceilings, the neutrality, and the featurelessness of its interior décor, the library resembles the concourse of an airport, the ultimate symbol of mobility and connectivity, not just to the city but to the world.

These elements all reflect what Shannon Mattern (2007, pp. ix–x) describes as recent public library developments’ tendency to embrace designs that are “newly transparent, legible, accessible [and] responsive to context” through their choice of “shapes and styles that speak to the cities and populations they serve.” As she notes, this ethos is not just symbolic and aesthetic. It is also pragmatic, oriented as much toward the policies and imperatives of libraries’ funding bodies and their city’s development strategies as architectural innovation and experimentation. “Star-architect” libraries might aspire to produce a “miniature Bilbao effect,” putting their city “on the map” by bringing “progressive architecture to an otherwise bland downtown” (Mattern, 2007, p. 22). They might also be rationalized within broader urban redevelopment schemes by injecting public space into otherwise sterile commercial developments (Mattern, 2007, p. 53).

Games and play might seem marginal in these libraries’ macro-level designs and operations. But as our examples reveal, games, play, and playfulness all figure into libraries’ engagement with the city and its development, from their intersection with their immediate environment to their fulfillment of their municipality’s economic and cultural policies. It is no coincidence that Oodi has embraced games and gaming, given the relative importance of the game development industry to Finland’s economy. The Finnish games industry has approx. 3,200 employees. Several globally successful game studios like Supercell (*Clash of Clans*) and Remedy (*Max Payne*) are based in Helsinki, as well as Arcade5 (n.d.), a co-working hub for game development start-ups (Neogames, 2019). Oodi’s spaces and programs directly support this game development community, from bookable meeting rooms used by various groups and clubs to its “Grasp the Games” game literacy sessions that educate the public about the cultural significance of games. Meanwhile, its various other facilities serve the city’s wider “smart region” strategy, which seeks to foster “innovation” and attract knowledge workers, of which game developers are a growing proportion (Helsinki Smart Region, n.d.; Helsinki-Uusimaa Regional Council, 2020). This extends to Oodi’s makerspace, Konehuone (“Engine Room”). Like other library makerspaces, it supports this agenda by providing what its manager Sanna Huttunen describes as “a place where you could actually get inspired and start developing something, maybe yourself, or maybe a project [. . .] it would be so cool if somebody actually got an idea of something that could be commercially used as well” (interview transcript, 2019).

Like Helsinki, Melbourne, the capital city of the state of Victoria, is also a hub for game development. Victoria hosts over 50% of the country’s game developers at the time of writing (see Forde, 2019; Keogh, 2017). State Library Victoria has a long association with this local game development community, having hosted the Freeplay Independent Games Festival between 2009 and 2013; and through its former “Experimedia” space, which served as a venue for interactive media and gaming events between 2003 and 2017. The Library’s new “Create” and “Ideas” Quarters support game developers, start-ups, and other knowledge workers by providing co-working spaces, technology studios, and mentorship programs. Meanwhile, the Children’s Quarter, along with various other Australian libraries “Tech for Toddlers,” “LEGO literacy” and *Minecraft*-oriented programs all support the early digital literacy and digital inclusion strategies of their funding bodies across different levels of government.

Our case studies indicate that, like their 19th-century counterparts, libraries continue to program games and play to support education and attract new patrons. But alongside this historical

continuity, games and play are also instrumental to the reconfiguration of libraries as they adapt to 21st-century challenges of digitization, funding imperatives, and urban development agendas. This is visible in the physical design of libraries: playful interior décor, dedicated makerspaces, and porous architecture that connects the library to urban parks, playgrounds, and outdoor public spaces. It is visible also in their alignment with policies of urban and economic development, like supporting game development and other creative industries through facilities, programs, and festivals. Crucially, these trends advance the wider conscription of libraries into neoliberal governance through “smart city,” “digital-by-default,” and urban redevelopment initiatives like those of Helsinki, Melbourne, and Singapore. And of course, like the wider process of urban economic redevelopment, these trends are uneven and variegated. Our key case studies in this article are mostly expensive, high-profile (re)developments in countries with strong library investments. As such, they might seem to contrast with the austerity policies imposed on libraries in the United Kingdom, parts of Europe, the United States, and Latin America (EveryLibrary, 2020; Forkert, 2016; Giannakopoulos et al., 2014). Nonetheless, we would argue that they are far from anomalies, but represent the library’s strategic response to pressures and imperatives that are confronting public institutions around the world.

On one level, this trend provides further evidence of the co-optation of play and leisure by corporations, institutions, and governments that play scholars have been lamenting since Huizinga’s (1944/1949) seminal book (Ch 12). This argument has gained further traction in the digital era, as theorists identify the potential for play to be instrumentalized through discourses and policy agendas that serve visions of post-industrial urban development, digital capital, and the entrepreneurial citizen (see, e.g., Dyer-Witheford & de Peuter, 2009; Kücklich, 2005; Lütticken, 2010; Nieuwenhuys, 1980/1998; Wark, 2007). At the molecular level of the individual, these agendas are advanced through children’s play programs which enroll them in the literacies of digital production and consumption, as well as acclimatize them to the disposition of self-sufficient and flexible citizenship. Makerspaces, gaming literacy sessions, and incubator programs for game developers and other creative workers are often steeped in the rhetoric of entrepreneurship, innovation, and the digital economy. Children’s storytime and play, meanwhile, are explicitly linked to the development of coding skills, digital literacy, and STEAM-based (science, technology, engineering, arts, and maths) learning via interactive storytelling, *Minecraft*, and gamification tools. The co-location of libraries like Iso Omena and Melbourne’s Bargoonga Nganjin North Fitzroy Library with child and maternal health care centers reinforces the “soft” governance of community development. This creates opportunities for a holistic blending of children’s care, education, play, and leisure, undoubtedly supporting families’ lives, but also serving technocratic and instrumentalist imperatives. At the level of both the city and the citizen, these examples indicate the way that games and play propel libraries into the realms of work and economic development.

It is easy to paint here a pessimistic picture of libraries wholly absorbed into the project of the neoliberal state. As the library becomes a playground, it loses its specificity and becomes more and more like other spaces: less a “third space” separate from home and work than a mediating space between them. In this interpretation of the contemporary library, it might be said to contribute to a culture where freedom is paired with precarity, where the skills of play are essential to being economically competitive, and where sociality is reduced to “networking.” However, even as the library staff we spoke to acknowledged and promoted their libraries’ alignment with urban development and policy discourses, they continued to hold to its value as a “third place.”¹ This was not only articulated explicitly but also indirectly as they insisted upon the importance of the library as a space that is “safe,” “warm,” and “quiet” (Hanna transcript, 2016); “free” and “welcoming” to everyone, whether “you’re a homeless person looking for a bit of respite [or] an author writing the next great literary work” (Torney transcript, 2017); and where people “come together, share information, collaborate with each other” (Liau transcript, 2017). This recurrent invocation

of the third place might be a way to articulate the enduring humanistic and communal aspects of libraries, tethering them to their traditional roles in public life and providing a counter to the neo-liberal and technocratic discourse that increasingly informs their funding, governance, and day-to-day operation. These two facets of the library—the communal and the entrepreneurial—indicate, as we have argued elsewhere (Leorke and Wyatt, 2019), that public libraries play multiple roles in the city and like play itself, cannot be reduced to a binary logic.

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Notes

1. For instance, Forde transcript, 2019; Hyde transcript, 2017; Lindberg transcript, 2020; Sivula transcript, 2020. Interestingly, in some cases, the interviewee incorrectly used the phrase “third space,” perhaps reaffirming the third place’s status as a loose, lofty metaphor rather than a concrete concept.
- i. The authors would like to thank all the librarians, library staff, and other professionals who were interviewed for this research for sharing their experiences, stories, and insights.

Supplemental Material

Supplemental material for this article is available online.

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